CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

WEB DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

Your beginner product used to be 'a website.' A website is now a text prompt and thirty seconds. The tool doesn't assist this job — the tool's output is this job.

★ TL;DR — Our take: NO — not as a standalone 2027 start. The title's own median is ~$63K (ZipRecruiter), and the prettier BLS number people quote ($104,000 designer line) belongs to the parent occupation's UX/product tier — a different job with a different door, which is Door A below. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$63K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK MEDIUM

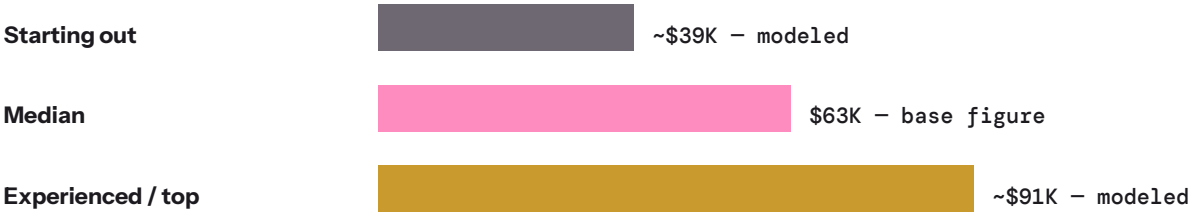
- The basis trap: BLS counts this work inside Web Developers and Digital Designers ($99,520 blended, +5%), but the split is the story — the $104,000 line prices product-org UX roles, while the web-design title itself medians ~$63K on the market.

- The demand data is measured, not vibes: post-ChatGPT platform studies found web development postings down ~20% in the first year of generative tools, and Tufts' AI Jobs Risk Index names web designers among the highest-displacement occupations in its class.

- The beginner's deliverable — marketing sites, landing pages, small-business pages in a builder — is produced end-to-end by AI site builders and coding agents. The client who used to hire the junior is now the tools' target customer.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Web Designer is a ~$63K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A WEB DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Design and build marketing and small-business websites in builders or code
- ✓ Structure pages around conversion: calls, bookings, sales
- ✓ Handle client feedback, revisions, launches and maintenance
- ✓ Assemble layouts, typography and imagery into a finished page

Think: a shopfitter for the internet — except the shop now arrives flat-packed from a prompt, and the paid human work moved upstairs into deciding what the shop should make people do.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
The whole beginner product: complete generic websites from a paragraph, landing pages, template customization, first-pass copy and imagery. Wix's AI builder, Framer AI and their rivals sell directly to your would-be clients.	Product judgment: research, information architecture, interaction design, design systems, and accountability for whether the thing converts. That layer lives inside the UX/UI tier — it is a different title, hired differently, at a different median.

⚠ **Do not let anyone sell you this roadmap with the $104,000 figure in the window. That number prices UX and product designers inside tech employers. The web-design title's own market — ~$63K median, ~$52K at the 25th percentile — is the honest starting point, and its freelance demand has already measurably fallen.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Visual craft with fast, visible results ✓ The skills genuinely transfer upward into product design ✓ Freelance flexibility, if you can sell	✗ Your direct competitor is a free tool your client already opened ✗ The adjacent pure-design occupation (Graphic Designers, $62,960) is projected to decline −2% ✗ WEF lists graphic designers among declining roles — the design-only layer is named, not implied

Good fit? Already shipping sites and hungry to move up into product work — research, flows, systems. For you this map is a promotion plan, and Door A is close.
Bad fit? Anyone planning to earn a living in 2027 assembling templated small-business sites. That product has a new manufacturer, and it charges $0–20 a month.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO UX/UI Designer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO CRM / Email Marketer
The surviving design tier, with real federal numbers: BLS Web Developers and Digital Designers median $99,520 blended — $104,000 on the designer line — with +5% growth and ~13,600 openings a year. This is the same visual talent pointed at product problems: user research basics, flows, prototypes, design systems, and decisions a business can measure. First move: take your best site project and redo it as a product case — problem, research, flow, prototype, result — because that case, not a gallery of homepages, is what this tier hires from.	The other place page-craft converts to money: lifecycle email and CRM work anchors to BLS Market Research Analysts and Marketing Specialists at $78,760 with +7% growth. Nobody's inbox is a template demo — revenue per send is measured, and designers who understand layout, hierarchy and persuasion start ahead. First move: rebuild one client's (or a demo brand's) email flow end to end and report what it earned or would earn; that number is your interview.

Smart move: Sell outcomes with numbers attached — conversion, bookings, revenue per email — or don't sell at all. 'I design websites' competes with a prompt; 'my pages convert at X' competes with other humans.
Where you land after: You land in the tier the tools feed instead of eat: product design with a federal growth line under it, or lifecycle marketing where your layout skill prints measurable revenue.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ACCEPT WHICH	LEARN THE	RESEARCH BASICS	REBUILD ONE	SYSTEMS AND	APPLY TO

STEP 1 — Accept which number is yours

TODAY · FREE

- Compare the title median (~$63K) with the UX tier's designer line ($104,000) and decide which job you're actually training for.
- List your current deliverables and mark which ones a site builder now produces unaided.

STEP 2 — Learn the product layer

WEEKS 1-4

- UX fundamentals: user goals, information architecture, flows, usability heuristics.
- Study product case studies — note how every one is a decision story, not a screenshot gallery.

STEP 3 — Research basics

MONTHS 1-2

- Run five usability tests on anything real; write findings a skeptic would accept.
- Learn to read analytics: where users drop is where design work begins.

STEP 4 — Rebuild one project as a product case

MONTHS 2-3

- Take your best site and redo it as problem → research → flow → prototype → outcome.
- Prototype in Figma to clickable depth; pretty static screens don't count.

STEP 5 — Systems and handoff depth

MONTHS 3-4

- Components, variants, design tokens — the systems work builders can't improvise.
- Learn what developers need from you; handoff fluency is a hiring filter.

STEP 6 — Apply to the tier that grows

MONTHS 4-6

- Target UX/UI and product design postings with the case-led portfolio.
- Keep one freelance revenue line (Door B work counts) — proof of commercial value travels well.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: write the two medians side by side — $63K title, $104,000 designer line. Train for the second.

□ Days 1–30: UX fundamentals plus analytics literacy; audit your portfolio and mark everything a builder can now make.

□ Days 31–60: usability testing practice and one product case rebuilt from your best project.

□ Days 61–90: systems depth in Figma, portfolio relaunched as decision cases, applications out to UX/UI roles.

□ Day 90: you're a product-design candidate with a case that shows judgment — not a site assembler competing with a prompt.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ PAGES ARE PROMPTS NOW. JUDGMENT ISN'T. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.